

Une Faible Impression (*A Faint Impression*)

Written by

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A man, MAN, sits contemplatively on a bench. In the distance the sun slowly rises, but he ignores it for a NOTEBOOK, which lies on his lap. He takes a deep breath and picks up his PEN, ready to write.

MAN (v.o.)

Chère Maman... Je pense à toi. (Dear Mom... I miss you.)

MAN, unsatisfied, scratches out the words. He exhales and starts again.

MAN (v.o.)

Chère Maman... Je réfléchissais à l'idée de marche en avant... Et ça m'a rappelé notre voyage en train de Toulouse à... Je ne sais plus où... (Dear Mom... I have started thinking about progress... And it reminded me of our train ride from Toulouse to... I can't remember where...)

MAN, still unsatisfied, scratches out the words. He takes a final breath and starts once more.

MAN (v.o.)

Maman... Je repensais à notre dernière conversation... Que voulais-tu dire quand tu as dit : «Il faut entendre le mot avec la résonance du monde.» Maman, dis-moi... parce que le mot-- (Mom... I was thinking about our last conversation... What did you mean when you said, "One must hear the word with the sound of the world?" [Pause] Mother, tell me...because the word--)

MAN forgets the word in French. Beckon... How does that translate?

WOMAN (o.s.)

Appelle...

MAN does not notice/acknowledge the voice. He continues searching for the lost word.

MAN

Le mot... beckons...

WOMAN (o.s.)

Appelle...

MAN hears something. He slowly looks around at Nature, searching for the source. Is it his mother? The wind? He goes back to his NOTEBOOK.

MAN
Le mot... *beckons*...

WOMAN (o.s.)
Appelle...

MAN remembers the word. *Appelle*. He begins writing.

A WOMAN, early 30s, is sitting on a parallel bench across the lookout.

MAN (v.o.)
Le mot m'appelle loin du confort...
(*The word beckons me away from
comfort...*)

WOMAN
Come here often?

MAN
(surprised)
Huh?

WOMAN
(louder)
Do you come here often?

MAN
Ah... yes. In the mornings, you?

WOMAN
(smiles)
Wouldn't you know, if you come here often?

MAN
(smiles back)
Not with certainty.

WOMAN
Just passing through. Duluth.
Keokuck. Now... As good a stop as
any, wouldn't you say?

MAN
Why?

WOMAN gestures towards the landscape with her eyes.

MAN
Why are you passing through?

WOMAN prepares for a big anecdote.

MAN
(cuts her off)
What are you reading?

WOMAN
Oh, Pushkin.

WOMAN holds up the BOOK. It's a worn copy of *Eugene Onegin*.

MAN
In Russian?

WOMAN
No, translation.

MAN
(disinterested)
Oh.

MAN returns to his NOTEBOOK. WOMAN slowly pulls out a small, folded MAP.

WOMAN
Would you happen to know the way out?

MAN
Straight down. Take a right at the sycamore by the bend. Then you'll hit the main road.

WOMAN
What does a sycamore look like?

MAN
If you have gone too far, you'll know.

MAN closes his NOTEBOOK and stands up. He takes a few steps, then lights a CIGARETTE.

WOMAN folds the map and returns to her book.

WOMAN
(while reading)
If it's not translatable, why do we bother?

MAN
(defeated)
Hmm... Feeble meaning is better than nothing at all.

A gust of wind blows through the trees. MAN and WOMAN are taken by surprise.

WOMAN
Is it a poem?

MAN
Something like that. [Laughs] It
doesn't rhyme.

WOMAN stands up and takes a few steps. She looks into the distance.

A stronger gust of wind blows through. MAN's SHEET OF PAPER flies away. It twists and turns in the air. MAN slowly chases it.

WOMAN
Hah... He has a very rebellious turn
of mind...

Slowly, WOMAN follows MAN. MAN picks up the fallen PAPER.

2 EXT. WOODS/FOREST - DAYTIME

2

A young boy, BOY, 7, picks up some soil. He thinks he hears his name and turns in its direction. What is its source?

Slowly, he walks. Is he being pulled or is he searching?

3 EXT. PARK ROAD - MOMENTS LATER

3

MAN and WOMAN are walking on the road. MAN puts his LIGHTER in his pocket.

WOMAN
(comfortable, smoking)
On my way up from Ste. Genevieve,
train got delayed... because of
another train... Man behind me gets
a call from his wife... She's angry
because surely he is cheating
again... Hah...

MAN
You said you came from Keokuck...

WOMAN
I misspoke...

They walk in silence.

WOMAN (cont.)
The train stops half a mile too far.
He passes her house on the train...
to get to her house...

MAN
Feels like fate, no?

WOMAN
I am indifferent to fate.

MAN
A half-mile walk isn't too far, if
it takes you home.

WOMAN
Every time I go home, this tiredness
overcomes me...

MAN and WOMAN look up. They notice a small beauty. Is it a
tree? A bird?

4 EXT. WOODS - MOMENTS LATER

4

BOY navigates through the woods. He cuts through bushes
and trees. He arrives at an opening.

WOMAN (v.o.)
It's so beautiful that you think you
discovered it...

MAN (v.o.)
And if we didn't?

WOMAN (v.o.)
But... it feels like the beginning
of a process, rather than an end in
itself...

MAN (v.o.)
Oh, beauty... [Pause] The blindness
to which it gave rise... If only we
could see.

WOMAN (v.o.)
What would we see?

MAN (v.o.)
We would see straight away that
something is true, and something is
false.

5 EXT. BOLLARD AREA/PARK - MOMENTS LATER

5

MAN and WOMAN weave through a set of bollards.

MAN
Cigarette?

WOMAN
No...

Man lights one more CIGARETTE for himself.

MAN
When do you leave?

WOMAN

Soon.

MAN

Stay another day. See the city.

WOMAN

No...

MAN

What's the hurry?

MAN and WOMAN sit on bollards.

WOMAN

Time... Maybe on a cooler, quieter day, I would have said yes...

MAN blows into the air. You can see his breath... Is it not cool enough? WOMAN smiles.

MAN

It takes two sunrises to know this town...

WOMAN

L'avenir nous prend les bras... Or something. (*The future seizes us by the arms - she meant to say, "L'avenir nous tend les bras/The future awaits us..." She misspeaks the phrase.*)

MAN is shaken by the phrase. He stops for a moment, trying to understand.

WOMAN (cont.)

Besides, I can't disappear. I'm to be wed in a month. Some altar requires my presence.

MAN

Oh, congratulations. Where's your—

WOMAN

Guatemala.

MAN

What for?

WOMAN

Digging wells.

MAN

Oh, commendable.

WOMANW

It's what drew me to him.

WOMAN stands up and takes a few steps.

MAN

And how do you manage the
separation?

WOMAN walks back. This time, she sits on a closer bollard.

WOMAN

I don't think about that. [Pauses]
To remember one thing while
excluding everything else is a
separation in itself.

MAN

Still it must be...

WOMAN

From time to time... And from time
to time he sends me photos of water
systems and children with
strange-shaped hats.

MAN gets up and walks away. WOMAN follows.

MAN

But you're creating different
memories...

WOMAN

All memories are an invention of
repression.

They walk in silence.

WOMAN (cont.)

Human consciousness is oriented
towards what hasn't arrived... You
cannot live without daydreaming...

MAN

I think there is another way...

WOMAN

Those who can dream of the Garden of
Eden are-

MAN

(cuts her off)
Eden is a memory...

WOMAN

To not dream means to die. And it's
never easy to die.

MAN

You cannot live without memory...
It's never easy to die.

WOMAN

Feel that?

MAN

What?

WOMAN

A hint of hatred dwells in that
belief... [Pause] The heart's memory
eliminates the bad and magnifies the
good. The mind's is quite the
opposite. Either way, it's catering
to first-world issues through a
first-world lens...

MAN

Tell me more.

WOMAN

The past. It's a Bourgeois
self-interest... And it likes to
draw all other interest into its own
failure...

MAN

Bourgeois?

MAN looks down at his clothes.

WOMAN

My words poorly portray my
thoughts...

MAN

Everything first sneaks in through
language. Action comes later... Read
me from your book.

WOMAN reads from book. (Insert passage)

MAN

I doubt you ever even notice when
the skies change from day to
night...

WOMAN

Hah... How can you tell?

MAN

The way you read...

WOMAN puts the book in her jacket pocket...

MAN
A beautiful jacket...

WOMAN
It was my mother's...

MAN
It reeks of genealogy... [Pause] The
best color for a jacket... and for
the leaves...

MAN walks away.

6 EXT. WOODS - CONTINUOUS

6

BOY walks through the opening, and sees a BED/MANGER in
the middle of the woods.

He slowly makes his way to it. He runs his hand over the
sheets. He gets on.

He starts jumping. Slowly, then faster.

He starts to turn. Suddenly, he stops. He sees something.
Tears well in his eyes.

A woman is standing in the distance.

7 EXT. LOVER'S LEAP/PARK - MOMENTS LATER

7

MAN and WOMAN sit on a ledge. WOMAN is reading from her
book. She pauses.

WOMAN
So you hate translations?

MAN
I don't hate them. In fact, I
succumb to them.

WOMAN
But nothing can ever be transmitted
in its entirety. Always a filtered
remainder.

MAN
So, what is lost?

WOMAN
It's lost on me now. But, we can't
help ourselves.

MAN
And why not?

WOMAN contemplates.

MAN
(mockingly)
Ah, so for preservation?

WOMAN
You twist my words.

MAN
You twist your own words! Language
itself is a filtering of its own.

WOMAN
Language is just a mode of
communication.

MAN
Yes, but not poetry. [Pause]
Communication transmits what is
already known. But what about the
unknown? [Pause] What about the
moment when something within the
human being becomes too complete,
too charged, too coherent to remain
unexpressed... and therefore must
take shape in the world?

WOMAN
(mockingly)
Oh, so a becoming?

MAN
You complicate the solution much
beyond the problem itself... A poem
makes you feel that something was
felt. Expression is its arrival.

WOMAN
Beauty is futural in action.

MAN
It is elegaic in substance.

MAN and WOMAN sit in silence.

MAN
If it is both, then perhaps it can
never be perceived.

WOMAN
Beauty isn't a prisoner of
perception. It's the master of it,
and in that sense, beauty is simply
presence.

MAN
And what about the presence of
(MORE)

MAN (CONT'D)
absence? I find that incredibly
beautiful.

WOMAN
You must have your reasons.

MAN chuckles.

WOMAN
Some want time measured out. Some
want it felt.

MAN and WOMAN sit in silence, deadlocked. This time,
Nature remains silent too.

Instead, the trees, the skies, beauty itself, listen in.

MAN and WOMAN are one with Nature.

WOMAN
How old are the trees? The skies?

MAN
And the wind?

WOMAN
It's hard to say.

MAN
It's hard to know.

8 EXT. WOODS - CONTINUOUS

WOMAN, now old, stands in the forest. She looks somberly
into the distance.

8